Social Media Use and Study Focus among Medical Students

Findings report: a survey of 98 medical students across 13 institutions

Analysis by Abdulakeem Olajide Jimoh | Data collected 30 October to 4 November 2026

98	13	2.74	70%	90%
respondents	institutions	average Distraction Index (1 to 5)	use social media 4+ hours a day	keep the phone beside them while studying

Summary

This report summarises an anonymous survey of 98 medical students from 13 institutions on how much time they spend on social media and how it affects their studying. Most respondents come from three schools: Bayelsa Medical University (36%), the University of Ilorin (33%) and Benson Idahosa University (18%). Just over half (54%) are aged 21 to 23 and 43% are aged 18 to 20. Clinical students make up 78% of the sample and preclinical students 22%.

Key findings

- **Heavy use is the norm.** 70% spend four or more hours a day on social media and 38% spend more than five. Only 5% spend under two hours.
- **More hours, more distraction.** The average Distraction Index rises from 1.70 (under 2 hours) to 3.18 (over 5 hours). The link is moderate and statistically clear (Spearman rho = 0.36, $p < 0.001$).
- **Entertainment comes first.** 64% use social media mainly for videos and reels, 19% for socialising, 9% for academic discussion and 7% for news.
- **Delaying work is the main problem.** 32% often or always put off assignments or reading because of social media, compared with 24% who struggle to concentrate in lectures and 23% who scroll longer than intended.
- **Phones stay within reach.** 90% keep the phone beside them while studying.
- **Differences between groups are small.** Age group and academic level show no statistically significant difference. Students who mainly use social media for socialising are the least distracted (2.29, against 2.87 for entertainment users, $p = 0.03$), but this is an exploratory comparison.

About the study

Data. An anonymous online survey of undergraduate MBBS students was open from 30 October to 4 November 2026. It received 100 submissions, and two blank submissions were removed, leaving 98 usable responses. The data was cleaned in Power Query (ages grouped into bands, institution names standardised, academic level grouped into preclinical and clinical), and analysed with Excel, Power BI and Python. The full cleaning record is in the repository.

Questions. Respondents reported their age, institution, academic level, daily hours on social media, the time of day they use it most, their main purpose for using it, and where their phone is while they study.

Four statements about study distraction were rated from Never to Always.

Distraction Index. Each respondent's index is the average of their four distraction answers, scored Never = 1 to Always = 5, so it runs from 1 (never distracted) to 5 (always distracted). A score of 3.5 or above is called high distraction. Appendix A gives the full method.

Overall results

How much and when

Social media use is heavy. More than a third of respondents (38%) spend over five hours a day on it and another third (33%) spend four to five hours, so 70% are online for at least four hours daily. Evening is the busiest time (47%), followed by before bed (22%), afternoon (16%) and midnight (12%). Entertainment and video content is the most common main purpose (64%), followed by socialising (19%), academic discussion (9%) and news (7%). Almost nine in ten students (90%) keep their phone beside them while studying; 4% keep it in a bag and 6% place it elsewhere.

How distracted are students?

Self-reported distraction is moderate. The average Distraction Index is 2.74, between “Rarely” and “Sometimes” and closer to “Sometimes”. 27% of students score 3.5 or above. The most common problem is delaying academic work: 32% say social media often or always makes them postpone assignments or reading. Difficulty concentrating in lectures without checking the phone affects 24% often or always, while 55% say they never or rarely struggle. Scrolling longer than intended while studying is reported often or always by 23%, and “Sometimes” is the single most common answer (38%). Losing focus because of notifications affects 21%.

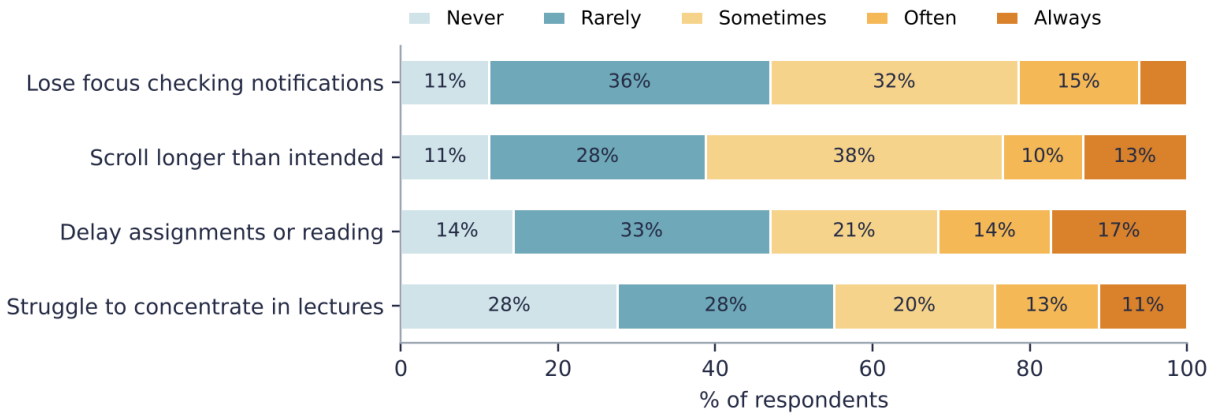


Figure 1. Responses to the four distraction statements (percentage of respondents).

More hours online, more distraction

Distraction rises steadily with time spent on social media. Students who spend over five hours a day average 3.18 on the Distraction Index, against 1.70 for those under two hours. The relationship is moderate (Spearman rho = 0.36, $p < 0.001$), and students above five hours score significantly higher than the rest ($p = 0.003$). Only five students use social media for under two hours, so that group's figure is indicative.

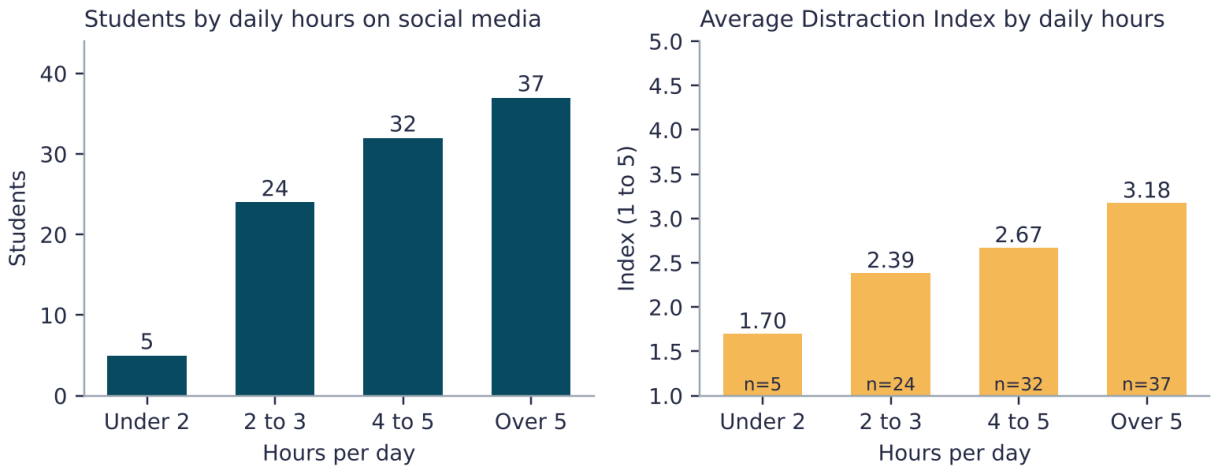


Figure 2. Respondents and average Distraction Index by daily hours on social media.

Time of day

Midnight users have the highest index among the larger groups (3.10, n = 12), against 2.58 to 2.69 for afternoon, evening and before-bed users. Across all times of day the differences are not statistically significant (p = 0.68), so this is a lead for future research rather than a finding. Only two students named the morning, so it is not interpreted.

Results by group

The dashboard has slicers for age group, current class and primary purpose. Each section below describes what the dashboard shows when one group is selected and compares it with all respondents. Groups with fewer than 10 students are marked † and should not be treated as findings.

Group	n	Index	High distraction	Over 5 hrs/day	Delay work (often/always)	Lecture focus (often/always)
All respondents	98	2.74	27%	38%	32%	24%
Age 18 - 20	42	2.86	31%	50%	33%	38%
Age 21 - 23	53	2.69	25%	25%	30%	15%
Age 24 and above	3 †	1.92	0%	100%	33%	0%
Clinicals	76	2.75	28%	39%	33%	24%
Preclinicals	22	2.72	23%	32%	27%	27%
Entertainment users	63	2.87	32%	41%	37%	30%
Socialising users	19	2.29	11%	21%	11%	5%
Academic-discussion users	9 †	2.94	33%	67%	33%	22%
News users	7 †	2.61	14%	14%	43%	29%

Table 1. Summary of all groups. Index = average Distraction Index (1 to 5); high distraction = index of 3.5 or above.

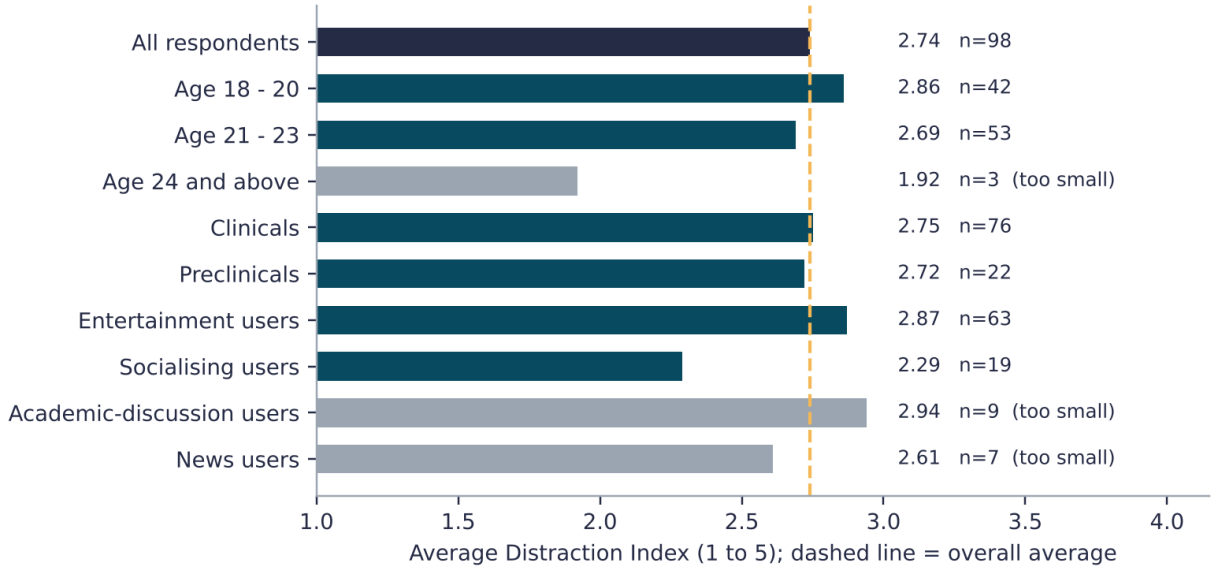


Figure 3. Average Distraction Index by group. Grey bars have fewer than 10 respondents.

Age group 18 - 20

The dashboard shows 42 respondents (43% of the sample) from 9 institutions, mainly Bayelsa Medical University (14), the University of Ilorin (12) and Benson Idahosa University (8). The average Distraction Index is **2.86**, above the overall 2.74. This group uses social media more heavily: half (50%) spend more than five hours a day, against 38% overall, and 81% spend at least four hours, against 70%. Entertainment is the main purpose for 74% (64% overall), followed by socialising (14%) and academic discussion (12%); no one in this group chose news. 88% keep the phone beside them while studying.

Distraction is more frequent than average on lecture concentration (38% often or always, against 24% overall), delaying work (33%, against 32%) and scrolling longer than intended (29%, against 23%). The group is also split, with 50% saying they never or rarely struggle to concentrate in lectures.

Age group 21 - 23

The dashboard shows 53 respondents (54% of the sample) from 7 institutions, mainly Bayelsa Medical University (20), the University of Ilorin (18) and Benson Idahosa University (10). The group is mostly clinical students (87%). The average Distraction Index is **2.69**. Use is lighter than in the full sample: a quarter (25%) spend more than five hours a day and 60% spend at least four. Entertainment is still the main purpose (58%), but socialising is more common (23%, against 19% overall), followed by news (11%) and academic discussion (8%). 91% keep the phone beside them.

Distraction is milder than average on lecture concentration (just 15% often or always, with 57% never or rarely) and scrolling (21%). Delaying assignments or reading remains the biggest issue at 30% (32% overall). Ten of these 53 respondents did not give a valid age and are counted in this group (see Data notes), so age comparisons involving it should be read with care.

Age group 24 and above

Only 3 respondents (3% of the sample) are in this group, so it is too small for any conclusion. They come from two institutions (one from Bayelsa Medical University and two from the University of Ilorin), and all three are clinical students. Their average Distraction Index is 1.92, the lowest of any group, but with three students it should not be treated as a finding. All three spend more than five hours a day on social media and keep the phone beside them while studying. Their main purposes differ: news, entertainment and socialising. All three say they never or rarely struggle to concentrate in lectures, and one often or always delays assignments. A single student changes this group's percentages by a third.

Age group comparison. Students aged 18 - 20 score slightly higher than those aged 21 - 23 (2.86 against 2.69), driven by heavier use and a stronger focus on entertainment. The difference is not statistically significant (p = 0.61), so it should be read as a pattern to watch.

Current class: Clinicals

The dashboard shows 76 clinical students (78% of the sample) from 8 institutions, led by Bayelsa Medical University (32), the University of Ilorin (21) and Benson Idahosa University (17). The average Distraction Index is **2.75**, essentially the same as the overall 2.74. 71% spend at least four hours a day on social media and 39% spend over five. Entertainment is the main purpose for 68%, followed by socialising (18%), news (8%) and academic discussion (5%). 91% keep the phone beside them while studying.

Delaying assignments or reading is the biggest problem (33% often or always), followed by scrolling longer than intended (25%) and difficulty concentrating in lectures (24%). 28% of clinical students score 3.5 or above.

Current class: Preclinicals

The dashboard shows 22 preclinical students (22% of the sample) from 9 institutions, 11 of them from the University of Ilorin. The average Distraction Index is **2.72**, almost identical to clinical students. Use is slightly lighter (68% spend at least four hours a day and 32% more than five), and 23% score 3.5 or above. Their purposes are more varied: entertainment 50%, socialising 23% and academic discussion 23% (against 5% for clinicals). Lecture concentration is often or always a problem for 27% and delaying work for 27%, while only 18% scroll longer than intended. With 22 students, each person moves a percentage by about 4.5 points.

Class comparison. Clinical (2.75) and preclinical (2.72) students are almost identical (p = 0.73). Distraction does not appear to be tied to the stage of training.

Primary purpose: Entertainment and videos

The dashboard shows 63 respondents (64% of the sample) from 9 institutions. Their average Distraction Index is **2.87**, above the overall 2.74, and 32% score 3.5 or above. This group uses social media heavily: 71% spend at least four hours a day and 41% more than five. 92% keep the phone beside them while studying. Delaying work is the biggest problem (37% often or always), followed by lecture concentration (30%) and scrolling longer than intended (27%). 83% are clinical students.

Primary purpose: Socialising and chatting

The dashboard shows 19 respondents (19% of the sample) from 6 institutions. Their average Distraction Index is **2.29**, the lowest of the groups with 10 or more students, and only 11% score 3.5 or above. They use social media less than average (58% spend at least four hours a day, 21% more than five). Few report problems: only 5% often or always struggle to concentrate in lectures, 11% delay work and 16% scroll longer than intended. This group scores significantly lower than entertainment users (p = 0.03). Because several comparisons were made, treat this as a lead for further study.

Primary purpose: Academic discussions and study groups †

Only 9 respondents (9% of the sample) chose this purpose, and 7 of them are from the University of Ilorin, so the group is too small and too concentrated to interpret. Their average Distraction Index is 2.94, the highest of any purpose, and 6 of the 9 spend more than five hours a day on social media. One possible explanation worth testing is that study-group chats are themselves a source of interruptions.

Primary purpose: News and current affairs †

Only 7 respondents (7% of the sample) chose news, so no conclusions can be drawn. Their average Distraction Index is 2.61, close to the overall figure, and 6 of the 7 spend at least four hours a day on social media.

Purpose comparison. Across all four purposes the overall differences are not statistically significant ($p = 0.17$). The clearest contrast is between socialisers (2.29) and entertainment users (2.87). The academic and news groups are too small to compare.

Two filters together

These tables show the average Distraction Index when two slicers are applied at once. Combinations with fewer than 10 students are marked † and are not reliable; combinations with no respondents show a blank page on the dashboard.

Age group and current class

Age group	Class	n	Avg index
18 - 20	Clinicals	27	2.94
18 - 20	Preclinicals	15	2.73
21 - 23	Clinicals	46	2.70
21 - 23	Preclinicals	7 †	2.68
24 and Above	Clinicals	3 †	1.92
24 and Above	Preclinicals	0	no data

Age group and primary purpose

Age group	Purpose	n	Avg index
18 - 20	Entertainment	31	3.06
18 - 20	Socializing	6 †	1.79
18 - 20	Academic	5 †	2.90
18 - 20	News	0	no data
21 - 23	Entertainment	31	2.69
21 - 23	Socializing	12	2.62
21 - 23	Academic	4 †	3.00
21 - 23	News	6 †	2.62
24 and Above	Entertainment	1 †	2.00
24 and Above	Socializing	1 †	1.25
24 and Above	Academic	0	no data
24 and Above	News	1 †	2.50

Current class and primary purpose

Class	Purpose	n	Avg index
Clinicals	Entertainment	52	2.85
Clinicals	Socializing	14	2.30
Clinicals	Academic	4 †	3.00
Clinicals	News	6 †	2.75
Preclinicals	Entertainment	11	2.93
Preclinicals	Socializing	5 †	2.25
Preclinicals	Academic	5 †	2.90
Preclinicals	News	1 †	1.75

Highlights. Entertainment users aged 18 - 20 are the most distracted large group (3.06, n = 31), against 2.69 for entertainment users aged 21 - 23 (n = 31). Clinical students aged 18 - 20 score 2.94 (n = 27). Socialisers have the lowest index in the combinations with enough students: 2.30 among clinical students (n = 14) and 2.62 among 21 - 23 year olds (n = 12), against 2.85 and 2.69 for entertainment users in the same groups.

What the results mean

Heavy social media use and constant phone proximity are the norm among these students, but the effect on study is uneven. Most report occasional rather than constant distraction, while a substantial minority (roughly a fifth to a third, depending on the statement) report frequent problems, especially with delaying assignments and reading. Time online is the clearest driver: distraction rises steadily with daily hours. What students use social media for matters too, with entertainment users more distracted than socialisers. Age group and stage of training make little difference.

Suggestions based on these results

- **Focus on heavy users.** Students above five hours a day score significantly higher. Study-time app limits or screen-time goals could help most here.
- **Support independent study.** Delaying assignments and reading is the biggest problem, so study-block schedules, accountability groups and assignment reminders may help more than lecture-focused measures.
- **Try putting the phone out of reach.** Nine in ten students keep it beside them. This survey cannot show whether moving it helps, so a small pilot would be worth running.
- **Time-box video use.** Because entertainment and reels dominate, scheduling video use outside study hours is a practical first step.
- **Follow up with a larger sample** from more schools, ideally adding measured screen time rather than self-report only.

These are suggestions drawn from the pattern of results, not tested interventions.

Limitations and data notes

- **Self-reported, cross-sectional data.** The results show associations, not cause and effect.
- **Convenience sample.** Three schools make up 87% of responses, so the results describe this group and should not be generalised to all medical students.
- **Missing ages.** Ten respondents gave no valid age and are counted in the 21 - 23 group during cleaning.

- **Small groups.** Ages 24 and above (3), academic-discussion users (9), news users (7) and morning users (2) are too small to interpret.
- **Banded hours.** The survey has no option between “2 to 3 hours” and “4 to 5 hours”.
- **Statistical tests.** Group comparisons use Mann-Whitney U or Kruskal-Wallis tests, and the hours relationship uses Spearman's rho. With many comparisons and small groups, p-values below 0.05 are indicative rather than conclusive.
- **Ethics.** Responses were anonymous and email addresses were removed before analysis.

Appendix A: How the Distraction Index is calculated

The Distraction Index is a single score that summarises how much social media interferes with a student's studying. It is based on four survey statements:

- I lose focus during study sessions because I check social media notifications.
- I spend more time scrolling on social media than intended when I am supposed to be studying.
- Social media distraction causes me to delay completing academic assignments or reading notes.
- I find it difficult to maintain concentration on lecture materials without checking my phone.

Answer	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often	Always
Score	1	2	3	4	5

Each respondent's index is the average of their four scores, so it ranges from 1 (never distracted) to 5 (always distracted). For example, a student who answered Often, Sometimes, Often and Rarely scores (4 + 3 + 4 + 2) ÷ 4 = 3.25. The overall index is the average of all respondents' scores, and when a slicer is applied it is the average for the selected group only.

High distraction is a score of 3.5 or above, midway between “Sometimes” and “Often”. **Reliability:** the four statements are internally consistent (Cronbach's alpha = 0.85), which supports combining them into one score.